

Tete is also a poster child of how far women's hockey has come. Hailing from Simdega in Jharkand, one of India's hockey cradles, her story has inspired more tribal girls to pick up the stick. "Simdega hostel is seeing more hockey prospects," she says. "There's more support too—monetary compensation, healthy food and better facilities like grounds with astro turf."

Kaur, too, has seen women's hockey flourish since the team's historic showing in Tokyo, where it finished fourth. A diverse squad, with players from Jharkand, Odisha, Haryana, Manipur, Mizoram and more, has created a balance of skill and speed. "Earlier, there wouldn't be much competition at the state level. Now, there's not much difference in [playing] levels," says Kaur. The sport's appeal has also widened in turn, with the world cup qualifiers seeing a great turnout in Hyderabad.

It's why Tete and Kaur know that what they do on the field will have a lasting impression. "It's what our coach says—'You don't have to play for yourself but for other girls too'." 2026, with its big tournaments, will give them an opportunity to script more history. ■

—Suhani Singh

along with full smashes. Last year gave me the confidence that I can beat the best players, but I need to be more consistent," says Shetty.

In a team featuring Lakshya Sen, Kidambi Srikanth and H.S. Prannoy, Shetty is the second-highest ranked singles player. "A team event is always different. There is pressure, but there is also more energy. Getting to play alongside Prannoy, Srikanth and Lakshya is very special," he adds.

In the Uber Cup, P.V. Sindhu will lead a young side including Unnati Hooda, Devika Sihag, Isharani Baruah, Tanvi Sharma and Tanisha Crasto. "There's a good mix of youth and experience in both teams. Senior players bring stability and the youngsters are in great form. They've shown they can deliver at this level, which gives you confidence going into the tournament," says Sanjay Mishra, general secretary of Badminton Association of India.

With team spirit as the driving force, now would be a good time for the young shuttlers to step up. ■

—Shail Desai

SQUASH ▼

ON A WINNING STREAK

Boosted by their Indian Open wins, squash players Abhay and Anahat Singh look to carry their form into the Asian Games this year

A lot can happen over a year. Ask Anahat Singh. In April 2025, the squash exponent was ranked outside the world top 60. Over the next few months, she took bronze at the World Junior Championships and finished runners-up at the U-19 British Junior Open, besides putting in consistent performances on the senior circuit. Then came the big one—the Squash on Fire Open in Washington DC, where she beat three higher-ranked players to claim the PSA World Tour Bronze title. It propelled her to World No. 18. Last month, she won the ASF Women's under-19 Player of the Year award.

Abhay Singh, winner of the ASF Men's Player of the Year award, cracked the top 50 in April 2025 and now has a ranking of World No. 25. "Abhay's growth has come from a combination of clarity in his game style and a big jump in his physical and mental consistency," says his coach Harinder Pal Singh Sandhu.

Both were part of the World Cup-winning squad alongside Joshna Chinappa and Velavan Senthilkumar in December 2025. Their latest triumph came at the Indian Open in March, where Anahat and Abhay won their respective singles categories. They will look to carry the form to the Asian Games this year.

"Greg (Gaultier) and Stephane (Galifi) have been preparing me to play the big matches as I transition from juniors to seniors. Off the court, I've been focusing on fitness, prehab and mobility," says Anahat. She is carrying out a delicate balancing act too. "It's my 12th grade, so there is a lot of studying to do," she says. Clearly, this 18-year-old can handle pressure of all sorts. ■

—Shail Desai

BOTH ABHAY AND ANAHAT WERE PART OF INDIA'S WORLD CUP-WINNING SQUAD AND WON SINGLES TITLES AT THE INDIAN OPEN IN MARCH



ANI

TOP OF THEIR GAMES Abhay and Anahat Singh achieved career-best world rankings this year